BOUNCING FORWARD

Everyone thinks you're 'fine'. But are you really?

YOUR WORKBOOK



A note from Maher

Thank you for giving yourself this hour. People who hold it all together rarely stop long enough to ask what it is costing them, so the fact that you did matters.

Bouncing Forward is built on one question: what does this ask of me? This webinar adds the second half, the one that lightens the load: what doesn't it ask of me?

These pages are a way to see your load clearly, share more of it, and set some of it down. A limit is not a lack of care. It is what keeps your care possible.

Go well, and keep bouncing forward.

Maher Kaddoura
Author of Bouncing Forward

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You jotted down three things during the webinar. This workbook is where they live from now on, with every other question from the hour.

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The whole hour in five lines, for whenever the load builds

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18 Seven days of small steps, and your weekly number
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How to use it

There is no right order and no deadline. The exercises follow the webinar, stage by stage, so you can start at the beginning or go straight to the one that stayed with you. Photograph your five-line plan and keep it on your phone. The page for the day the tabs pile up is for your busiest days. The compass questions are for Sunday evenings. The weekly number is for once a week, honestly. A pen, a quiet half hour, and the honest version of how you are: that is all it asks.

BEFORE THE PATH

Where we started

The webinar opened with the things we usually say, and the load nobody else can see. Start here, with the honest version.

1 When someone asks how you are, what do you usually say?

It's usually out before we've thought about it. Fine. Good, thanks. Managing. Keeping my head above water.

My usual answer

2 How many tabs are open in your life right now?

Not on your computer. In your head. Some tabs are tasks. Many are invisible: remembering, deciding, worrying ahead, keeping the peace.

Which kind of tab is heaviest for you right now?

☐ The tasks	☐ The remembering	☐ The worrying ahead	☐ Keeping the peace

Three tabs that are open today that nobody else can see

3 The little voice

If any of these sound familiar, this workbook is for you. The people who struggle most are often the ones who can cope with almost anything, for a very long time.

Tick the ones you've said to yourself

☐ "Other people have it far worse."	☐ "I should learn to cope better."
☐ "It's not big enough to say no to."	☐ "I'm fine, really."

4 My invisible job title

If everything you do for everyone else were a real job, what would it be called? Head of Family Logistics? Chief Remembering Officer? First Responder?

Roughly how many hours a week it takes

Whether it takes more time than the role I'm paid or thanked for

5 Two kinds of loss

The first shows up on the calendar. The second is quieter: the life you had pictured for this stage. Say it out loud, even just to yourself. It sits comfortably alongside all the love you have for the people in your life.

What used to be mine: time, sleep, evenings, weekends

The life I had pictured for this stage: the trip, the course, the quiet Saturday mornings

WHERE AM I NOW?

Honesty

Honesty simply means taking a clear look at where you are, and the best place to look is a day you've just lived.

6 Replay yesterday

From the moment you woke up: everything you did, remembered, decided or worried about for someone else. Aim for at least eight. Then circle the three that cost you the most energy, not the most time, and mark each one C (I chose this) or M (it simply became mine).

	What I did, remembered, decided or worried about for someone else	Top three	C or M
1		○	C / M
2		○	C / M
3		○	C / M
4		○	C / M
5		○	C / M
6		○	C / M
7		○	C / M
8		○	C / M

Number of things on my list

Times I dropped one thing to deal with someone else's

7 The one that cost the most

What drains us most is rarely the biggest job. It's the one we never chose, and never put down.

The thing I circled, and whether I chose it or it simply became mine

8 My number

How much of you is left for you at the end of an ordinary day? One is almost nothing; five is plenty. Just notice it.

Tick or colour in one.

1	2	3	4	5

Almost nothing *Plenty*

What I do to make that number look higher to everyone else: the cheerful voice, the "we're managing", the "I'm fine"

9 My capacity account

Every demand is a withdrawal. Everything that restores you is a deposit. Better organising adds no deposits: it moves the load around, same weight, neater arrangement.

Withdrawals: what takes something out of me	Deposits: what puts something back
1.	1.
2.	2.
3.	3.
4.	4.
One open tab I'll give a "when" to, and when	

STAGE ONE

Accept

Accept means looking at your load as it really is, and drawing a line between what's fixed and what's only familiar.

10 Three very reasonable things we tell ourselves

A bridge carrying twice its safe load is not praised for being strong. We reduce the load. And someone else may do it differently, and differently is very often good enough.

Tick the ones you recognise

☐ "I should be able to manage all of this."	☐ "Things will settle after this."
☐ "Nobody else can do it properly."	

My last "after" (year-end, the wedding, the move). Did things settle?

One thing someone else could do differently, and differently would be good enough

11 A limit is not a lack of care

A limit is what keeps your care possible over time, for the people who need you, and for you. A full tank, plus a bit in reserve.

Where a limit could go

What that limit would protect, for them and for me

12 Fixed or only familiar?

Left: what is genuinely fixed, like your working hours or the care a parent needs. Right: what you do because it has always been done that way. Familiar can safely move down the list.

Genuinely fixed	Only familiar
1.	1.
2.	2.
3.	3.
4.	4.
One familiar thing that could move	

13 Simply never asked

Research shows we badly underestimate how many people will say yes when asked directly. Most of them have simply never been asked.

Someone I have never actually asked	What I could ask them to take on

STAGE TWO

Reflect

Worry runs round the same track. Reflecting takes you somewhere new: what does this ask of me, and what doesn't it ask of me?

14 What does this ask of me? And what doesn't it?

Take the thing you circled in Replay yesterday, or the heaviest load you carry. Very often the extra weight in the right-hand column comes from guilt.

The load I'm looking at

What this asks of me	What it doesn't ask of me
1.	1.
2.	2.
3.	3.
4.	4.

15 Responsibility or guilt?

Making sure a parent gets to the doctor is responsibility. Being the only one of the siblings who ever drives them is often guilt. Listen to your reason: "they'll think I don't care" and "I'll feel I've let them down" are the tell-tale signs.

Real responsibility	What guilt has added
1.	1.
2.	2.
3.	3.
4.	4.
The conversation I've already played out in my head: what I think they'll say if I say no	
What they would most likely say in real life (research shows people are far less hurt by a no than we expect)	

16 The sentences guilt hides in

Each one is a strength with no off-switch. Being all things to all people is very different from being all you can be.

	That's me	The strength behind it	Where it needs an off-switch
"If I don't do it, it won't be done properly."	☐	Responsibility	
"They need to be able to reach me at any time."	☐	Reliability	
"This is no time to lower my standards."	☐	High standards	
"Everyone has enough on their plate. I'll handle it."	☐	Independence	

Being all I can be, rather than all things to all people, would look like

17 What carried me through before?

Think of a hard time you came through. One word for something inside you, and one name for someone around you. They are still there: resilience and support.

A hard time I came through

One word

One name

18 Resilience includes recovery

Bamboo bends and straightens up again. The straightening up matters most. Build rest in long before you run out, and never underestimate a sense of humour.

What restores me, beyond sleep: the walk, the call, the cup of tea I finish while it's still hot

Something about the chaos I can laugh at, even a little

Deposit one: day and time

Deposit two: day and time

19 Who catches me?

You're everyone's net. Support can only lighten a load it can see, and people who hold it all together are experts at editing what they tell.

How I edit: the words and the smile I use to hide the load

Who I could give the unedited version to

Start small. One task

One person

20 Sort the load

Everything you do in a week, at home, at work, in your community and for family and friends. One question helps: if I stopped doing it for a month, who would actually notice?

Only I can do this	Someone else could do this	This could wait, or stop, for now
1.	1.	1.
2.	2.	2.
3.	3.	3.
4.	4.	4.

Is anything in column one something I've quietly made mine? (There's a name for it: gatekeeping.)

One thing from column two or three to share, change or set down

STAGE THREE

Imagine

Imagine isn't about getting life back to how it was. It's the next chapter, with a load you can actually live with.

21 One honest direction

Something like: "I'd like to keep doing what matters for my family, and still have one evening a week that's mine." Then check whose face comes to mind. A picture that lightens your load has your own face in it.

I'd like to keep… and still have…

Whose face comes to mind when I picture it

If it isn't mine, what I'd change

22 My repeatable week

An ordinary week you could do again and again without running out of yourself. Five small moves, and one of each is plenty. None needs money, only a decision and a conversation.

Stop one thing

Protect one block of time

Share one responsibility

Lower one standard

Leave one space empty

Because… (why this matters to me)

23 What's still good?

Real optimism has nothing to do with forced cheerfulness. It's noticing the laugh around the table, the voice note from a grandchild, the friend who says thank you.

Still good: one

Still good: two

Still good: three

A strength this season has shown me

STAGE FOUR

Action

For people who hold it all together, action rarely means doing more. The bravest action is usually subtraction: cancel, delegate, delay, decline, ask.

24 My 24-hour move

Ten minutes or less, starting with an action word, done before this time tomorrow. Giving it a "when" is what lets your mind close the tab.

It comes from

☐ What I circled in Replay yesterday	☐ The familiar thing that could move
☐ Column two or three	

My move (ask, hand over, cancel, delegate, decline…)

When

Check-in person (first name)

25 Delegate, or ask for support?

Delegating hands something over completely, the task and the deciding. Support means it stays yours, but you stop carrying it alone. If handing over feels too big, start with support.

For my move, I'm

☐ Handing it over completely	☐ Keeping it, but no longer carrying it alone

If I hand it over, the "how" I will let go of

26 My clear ask

"Shout if you need anything" rarely turns into help. A clear ask gives people something they can actually do: what, by when, and for how long.

Who I'll ask

By when, and for how long

Could you…

Instead of "I'm fine", I'll say

27 My handover note

If you were away for a week, would anyone know how? Half a page turns "nobody else can do it properly" into "here's how". The nerves usually leave after the ask, rather than before it.

The task that lives only in my head

The times

The numbers

If something goes wrong

How it's done

28 As life changes

A new grandchild, a new manager, a parent who needs a little more help. The road changes; you change the route and keep the destination. That's adaptability.

What has changed lately

How the way the load is shared needs to change

Restores me when rest isn't enough: one

Two

29 "Let me check and come back to you."

One sentence that stops the load building quite so fast. A moment to decide, rather than a reflex yes.

The next request I'll use it on, and who usually asks

BACK TO THE QUESTION

Where we ended

The load is the same, but now you can see it. Column one is shorter than you think.

30 Your compass, today

Whichever question feels hardest today points you to what needs attention next.

Resilience: when did I last make a deposit?

Support: who needs to see the real picture?

Optimism: what's still good?

Adaptability: what needs to change in how the load is shared?

The hardest one today

31 My number, again

If you took it again now, would it move, even a little? Often it does.

Tick or colour in one.

1	2	3	4	5

Almost nothing *Plenty*

32 The tab I closed

The message I sent, the thing I cancelled, or what I handed over.

33 Everyone thinks you're 'fine'. But are you really?

You don't have to carry it all to be someone people can count on. Go back to the first page and compare.

The next time someone asks how I am, the honest answer is

Thank you for giving yourself this hour. Go gently.

Your five-line plan

The whole hour in your own words. Five lines, ten minutes. Come back to this page whenever the load builds again.

1 Where I am now

Honesty. Right now I'm carrying… and what it's costing me is…

2 One familiar thing that could move

Accept. Fixed or only familiar.

3 One thing to share, change or set down

Reflect. From column two or three.

4 My repeatable week, because…

Imagine. Stop, protect, share, lower, leave one space empty.

5 My 24-hour move

Action. An action word, a when and a check-in person.

Photograph this page and keep it on your phone.

The webinar in two pages

Everything we covered, in the order we covered it.



How many tabs are open?

Many of the tabs in your head are invisible: remembering, deciding, worrying ahead, keeping the peace. Most of us are worn down by the load we carry in our heads as much as by the tasks.



Everyone thinks you're fine

From the outside it all looks under control, so more keeps coming your way: one more lift, one more committee, one more "Could you just…". The people who struggle most can often cope with almost anything.



Two kinds of loss

The time, sleep and weekends that used to be yours, and the life you had pictured for this stage. You can love the people in your life completely and still miss that life. Both are true at once.



Replay yesterday

List everything you did, remembered, decided or worried about for someone else, and circle the three that cost the most energy. What drains us most is rarely the biggest job. It's the one we never chose, and never put down.



Better organising adds no deposits

Every demand is a withdrawal from your capacity account, and recovery is a deposit. A better list only rearranges the withdrawals. Deciding when something will happen is what lets your mind close the tab.



Reduce the load

We would never praise a bridge for carrying twice its safe load. We would reduce the load. "I should be able to manage all of this" turns a question about the load into a judgement about you.



A limit is not a lack of care

A limit is what keeps your care possible over time, for the people who need you, and for you. Accepting what can't change frees your energy for what you can shape.



Fixed or only familiar

When we're tired, we treat far more of life as fixed than it really is. The Saturday shop, every birthday present, replying straight away: much of what feels fixed is only familiar, and familiar can move.



Guilt sounds like love

Real responsibility sits on one list, and what guilt has added sits on another. "They'll think I don't care" is guilt talking, and research shows people are far less hurt by a no than we expect. Kindness is a choice; guilt is a pressure.



Resilience includes recovery

Like bamboo, real resilience bends and then straightens up again. Recovery is part of strength: the early night, the walk, and the cup of tea you finish while it's still hot.



Support needs to see the load

Support can only lighten a load it can see, and people who hold it all together are experts at editing what they tell. Start small: one task, one person, the unedited version.



Column one is shorter than you think

Only I can do this, someone else could do this, this could wait or stop. Column one is usually shorter than you expect, and some of it may be something you have quietly made yours.



A repeatable week

You don't need an ideal life. You need a week you can repeat without running out of yourself. Stop one thing, protect one block of time, share one, lower one standard, leave one space empty.



Action is subtraction

For people who hold it all together, action rarely means doing more. Cancel, delegate, delay, decline or ask, with one move of ten minutes or less before this time tomorrow.



A clear ask and a handover note

"Shout if you need anything" rarely turns into help, and a clear ask does. Half a page of how-to turns "nobody else can do it properly" into "here's how", and most people have been waiting to be asked.



Optimism and adaptability

Real optimism notices what's still good. Adaptability changes the route and keeps the destination: as life changes, the way the load is shared changes too. "Let me check and come back to you."



Your road map

The path is the steps you take: Honesty, Accept, Reflect, Imagine and Action. The compass holds the strengths you lean on along the way: resilience, support, optimism and adaptability. Every one of them was yours before this hour, and it is still yours today.

Seven days of small steps

One small step a day. No catching up, no perfect streak. Just the next one.

Day 1	**Take your 24-hour move.** Then tell your check-in person you did it.	What I did
Day 2	**Replay today.** Add anything new to column two or three.	What I did
Day 3	**Say "Let me check and come back to you" once.** A moment to decide, rather than a reflex yes.	What I did
Day 4	**Make one clear ask.** Say what, by when, and for how long.	What I did
Day 5	**Write a handover note for one task.** Half a page is enough.	What I did
Day 6	**Keep one deposit in your diary.** A walk, a call, an early night. Treat it like an appointment.	What I did
Day 7	**Review.** Take your number again below. What moved?	What I did

Where am I now? Again.

Once a week, honestly. How much of you is left for you at the end of an ordinary day? One is almost nothing; five is plenty.

Date	How much of me is left (1 to 5)	What moved this week

For the day the tabs pile up

The day when everything lands at once. Read your "because" first, then write.

My reason, because

Which of today's tabs did I choose, and which simply became mine?

One tab I can close, share or let wait today, and who I'll ask

For the Sunday evening

When the week ahead looks full, check your compass. One line each. Then one step.

Resilience: when did I last make a deposit?

Support: who needs to see the real picture?

Optimism: what's still good?

Adaptability: what needs to change in how the load is shared?

One deposit and one ask this week, with a day and a time

Everything on bouncing-forward.com is free: the first chapter of Maher's book, the stories of people who have bounced forward, and a two-minute check that gives you your compass reading today.

Setbacks don't get the last word.